EZRA

THE RETURNED EXILES AND THE TEMPLE

1 In the first year of Cyrus king of Persia, that the word of
the LORD by the mouth of Jeremiah might be fulfilled, the
LORD stirred up the spirit of Cyrus king of Persia, so that he
made a proclamation throughout all his kingdom and also
put it in writing:

[2]"Thus says Cyrus king of Persia: The LORD, the God of
heaven, has given me all the kingdoms of the earth, and he
has charged me to build him a house at Jerusalem, which is
in Judah. [3]Whoever is among you of all his people, may his
God be with him, and let him go up to Jerusalem, which is in
Judah, and rebuild the house of the LORD, the God of Israel—
he is the God who is in Jerusalem. [4]And let each survivor, in
whatever place he sojourns, be assisted by the men of his place
with silver and gold, with goods and with beasts, besides free-
will offerings for the house of God that is in Jerusalem."

[5]Then rose up the heads of the fathers' houses of Judah
and Benjamin, and the priests and the Levites, everyone
whose spirit God had stirred to go up to rebuild the house of
the LORD that is in Jerusalem. [6]And all who were about them
aided them with vessels of silver, with gold, with goods,
with beasts, and with costly wares, besides all that was freely
offered. [7]Cyrus the king also brought out the vessels of the
house of the LORD that Nebuchadnezzar had carried away
from Jerusalem and placed in the house of his gods. [8]Cyrus

king of Persia brought these out in the charge of Mithredath
the treasurer, who counted them out to Sheshbazzar the
prince of Judah. [9]And this was the number of them: 30 basins
of gold, 1,000 basins of silver, 29 censers, [10]30 bowls of gold,
410 bowls of silver, and 1,000 other vessels; [11]all the vessels
of gold and of silver were 5,400. All these did Sheshbazzar
bring up, when the exiles were brought up from Babylonia
to Jerusalem.

2 Now these were the people of the province who came up
out of the captivity of those exiles whom Nebuchadnezzar
the king of Babylon had carried captive to Babylonia. They
returned to Jerusalem and Judah, each to his own town. [2]They
came with Zerubbabel, Jeshua, Nehemiah, Seraiah, Reelaiah,
Mordecai, Bilshan, Mispar, Bigvai, Rehum, and Baanah.

The number of the men of the people of Israel: [3]the sons of
Parosh, 2,172. [4]The sons of Shephatiah, 372. [5]The sons of Arah,
775. [6]The sons of Pahath-moab, namely the sons of Jeshua and
Joab, 2,812. [7]The sons of Elam, 1,254. [8]The sons of Zattu, 945. [9]The
sons of Zaccai, 760. [10]The sons of Bani, 642. [11]The sons of Bebai,
623. [12]The sons of Azgad, 1,222. [13]The sons of Adonikam, 666.
[14]The sons of Bigvai, 2,056. [15]The sons of Adin, 454. [16]The sons of
Ater, namely of Hezekiah, 98. [17]The sons of Bezai, 323. [18]The sons
of Jorah, 112. [19]The sons of Hashum, 223. [20]The sons of Gibbar,
95. [21]The sons of Bethlehem, 123. [22]The men of Netophah, 56.
[23]The men of Anathoth, 128. [24]The sons of Azmaveth, 42. [25]The
sons of Kiriath-arim, Chephirah, and Beeroth, 743. [26]The sons
of Ramah and Geba, 621. [27]The men of Michmas, 122. [28]The
men of Bethel and Ai, 223. [29]The sons of Nebo, 52. [30]The sons of

Magbish, 156. [31]The sons of the other Elam, 1,254. [32]The sons of
Harim, 320. [33]The sons of Lod, Hadid, and Ono, 725. [34]The sons
of Jericho, 345. [35]The sons of Senaah, 3,630.

[36]The priests: the sons of Jedaiah, of the house of Jeshua,
973. [37]The sons of Immer, 1,052. [38]The sons of Pashhur, 1,247.
[39]The sons of Harim, 1,017.

[40]The Levites: the sons of Jeshua and Kadmiel, of the sons
of Hodaviah, 74. [41]The singers: the sons of Asaph, 128. [42]The
sons of the gatekeepers: the sons of Shallum, the sons of Ater,
the sons of Talmon, the sons of Akkub, the sons of Hatita,
and the sons of Shobai, in all 139.

[43]The temple servants: the sons of Ziha, the sons of Hasupha,
the sons of Tabbaoth, [44]the sons of Keros, the sons of Siaha, the
sons of Padon, [45]the sons of Lebanah, the sons of Hagabah, the
sons of Akkub, [46]the sons of Hagab, the sons of Shamlai,
the sons of Hanan, [47]the sons of Giddel, the sons of Gahar, the
sons of Reaiah, [48]the sons of Rezin, the sons of Nekoda, the
sons of Gazzam, [49]the sons of Uzza, the sons of Paseah, the sons
of Besai, [50]the sons of Asnah, the sons of Meunim, the sons of
Nephisim, [51]the sons of Bakbuk, the sons of Hakupha, the sons
of Harhur, [52]the sons of Bazluth, the sons of Mehida, the sons
of Harsha, [53]the sons of Barkos, the sons of Sisera, the sons of
Temah, [54]the sons of Neziah, and the sons of Hatipha.

[55]The sons of Solomon's servants: the sons of Sotai, the sons
of Hassophereth, the sons of Peruda, [56]the sons of Jaalah, the
sons of Darkon, the sons of Giddel, [57]the sons of Shephatiah,
the sons of Hattil, the sons of Pochereth-hazzebaim, and the
sons of Ami.

[58] All the temple servants and the sons of Solomon's servants were 392.

[59] The following were those who came up from Tel-melah, Tel-harsha, Cherub, Addan, and Immer, though they could not prove their fathers' houses or their descent, whether they belonged to Israel: [60] the sons of Delaiah, the sons of Tobiah, and the sons of Nekoda, 652. [61] Also, of the sons of the priests: the sons of Habaiah, the sons of Hakkoz, and the sons of Barzillai (who had taken a wife from the daughters of Barzillai the Gileadite, and was called by their name). [62] These sought their registration among those enrolled in the genealogies, but they were not found there, and so they were excluded from the priesthood as unclean. [63] The governor told them that they were not to partake of the most holy food, until there should be a priest to consult Urim and Thummim.

[64] The whole assembly together was 42,360, [65] besides their male and female servants, of whom there were 7,337, and they had 200 male and female singers. [66] Their horses were 736, their mules were 245, [67] their camels were 435, and their donkeys were 6,720.

[68] Some of the heads of families, when they came to the house of the LORD that is in Jerusalem, made freewill offerings for the house of God, to erect it on its site. [69] According to their ability they gave to the treasury of the work 61,000 darics of gold, 5,000 minas of silver, and 100 priests' garments.

[70] Now the priests, the Levites, some of the people, the singers, the gatekeepers, and the temple servants lived in their towns, and all the rest of Israel in their towns.

3 When the seventh month came, and the children of Israel were in the towns, the people gathered as one man to Jerusalem. [2] Then arose Jeshua the son of Jozadak, with his fellow priests, and Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel with his kinsmen, and they built the altar of the God of Israel, to offer burnt offerings on it, as it is written in the Law of Moses the man of God. [3] They set the altar in its place, for fear was on them because of the peoples of the lands, and they offered burnt offerings on it to the LORD, burnt offerings morning and evening. [4] And they kept the Feast of Booths, as it is written, and offered the daily burnt offerings by number according to the rule, as each day required, [5] and after that the regular burnt offerings, the offerings at the new moon and at all the appointed feasts of the LORD, and the offerings of everyone who made a freewill offering to the LORD. [6] From the first day of the seventh month they began to offer burnt offerings to the LORD. But the foundation of the temple of the LORD was not yet laid. [7] So they gave money to the masons and the carpenters, and food, drink, and oil to the Sidonians and the Tyrians to bring cedar trees from Lebanon to the sea, to Joppa, according to the grant that they had from Cyrus king of Persia.

[8] Now in the second year after their coming to the house of God at Jerusalem, in the second month, Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel and Jeshua the son of Jozadak made a beginning, together with the rest of their kinsmen, the priests and the Levites and all who had come to Jerusalem from the captivity. They appointed the Levites, from twenty years old and upward, to supervise the work of the house of the LORD. [9] And

Jeshua with his sons and his brothers, and Kadmiel and his
sons, the sons of Judah, together supervised the workmen in
the house of God, along with the sons of Henadad and the
Levites, their sons and brothers.

10 And when the builders laid the foundation of the temple
of the LORD, the priests in their vestments came forward with
trumpets, and the Levites, the sons of Asaph, with cymbals,
to praise the LORD, according to the directions of David king
of Israel. 11 And they sang responsively, praising and giving
thanks to the LORD,

> "For he is good,
> for his steadfast love endures forever toward
> Israel."

And all the people shouted with a great shout when they
praised the LORD, because the foundation of the house of the
LORD was laid. 12 But many of the priests and Levites and heads
of fathers' houses, old men who had seen the first house,
wept with a loud voice when they saw the foundation of this
house being laid, though many shouted aloud for joy, 13 so
that the people could not distinguish the sound of the joyful
shout from the sound of the people's weeping, for the people
shouted with a great shout, and the sound was heard far away.

4 Now when the adversaries of Judah and Benjamin heard
that the returned exiles were building a temple to the LORD,
the God of Israel, 2 they approached Zerubbabel and the heads
of fathers' houses and said to them, "Let us build with you, for
we worship your God as you do, and we have been sacrificing

to him ever since the days of Esarhaddon king of Assyria who
brought us here." 3 But Zerubbabel, Jeshua, and the rest of
the heads of fathers' houses in Israel said to them, "You have
nothing to do with us in building a house to our God; but we
alone will build to the LORD, the God of Israel, as King Cyrus
the king of Persia has commanded us."

4 Then the people of the land discouraged the people of
Judah and made them afraid to build 5 and bribed counselors
against them to frustrate their purpose, all the days of Cyrus
king of Persia, even until the reign of Darius king of Persia.

6 And in the reign of Ahasuerus, in the beginning of his
reign, they wrote an accusation against the inhabitants of
Judah and Jerusalem.

7 In the days of Artaxerxes, Bishlam and Mithredath and
Tabeel and the rest of their associates wrote to Artaxerxes
king of Persia. The letter was written in Aramaic and trans-
lated. 8 Rehum the commander and Shimshai the scribe wrote
a letter against Jerusalem to Artaxerxes the king as follows:
9 Rehum the commander, Shimshai the scribe, and the rest of
their associates, the judges, the governors, the officials, the
Persians, the men of Erech, the Babylonians, the men of Susa,
that is, the Elamites, 10 and the rest of the nations whom the
great and noble Osnappar deported and settled in the cities
of Samaria and in the rest of the province Beyond the River.
11 (This is a copy of the letter that they sent.) "To Artaxerxes
the king: Your servants, the men of the province Beyond the
River, send greeting. And now 12 be it known to the king that
the Jews who came up from you to us have gone to Jerusalem.

They are rebuilding that rebellious and wicked city. They are
finishing the walls and repairing the foundations. [13]Now be
it known to the king that if this city is rebuilt and the walls
finished, they will not pay tribute, custom, or toll, and the
royal revenue will be impaired. [14]Now because we eat the salt
of the palace and it is not fitting for us to witness the king's
dishonor, therefore we send and inform the king, [15]in order
that search may be made in the book of the records of your
fathers. You will find in the book of the records and learn that
this city is a rebellious city, hurtful to kings and provinces,
and that sedition was stirred up in it from of old. That was
why this city was laid waste. [16]We make known to the king
that if this city is rebuilt and its walls finished, you will then
have no possession in the province Beyond the River."

[17]The king sent an answer: "To Rehum the commander
and Shimshai the scribe and the rest of their associates who
live in Samaria and in the rest of the province Beyond the
River, greeting. And now [18]the letter that you sent to us has
been plainly read before me. [19]And I made a decree, and search
has been made, and it has been found that this city from of old
has risen against kings, and that rebellion and sedition have
been made in it. [20]And mighty kings have been over Jerusalem,
who ruled over the whole province Beyond the River, to
whom tribute, custom, and toll were paid. [21]Therefore make
a decree that these men be made to cease, and that this city be
not rebuilt, until a decree is made by me. [22]And take care not
to be slack in this matter. Why should damage grow to the
hurt of the king?"

[23]Then, when the copy of King Artaxerxes' letter was read
before Rehum and Shimshai the scribe and their associates,
they went in haste to the Jews at Jerusalem and by force and
power made them cease. [24]Then the work on the house of God
that is in Jerusalem stopped, and it ceased until the second
year of the reign of Darius king of Persia.

5 Now the prophets, Haggai and Zechariah the son of Iddo,
prophesied to the Jews who were in Judah and Jerusalem,
in the name of the God of Israel who was over them. [2]Then
Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel and Jeshua the son of Jozadak
arose and began to rebuild the house of God that is in
Jerusalem, and the prophets of God were with them, sup-
porting them.

[3]At the same time Tattenai the governor of the province
Beyond the River and Shethar-bozenai and their associates
came to them and spoke to them thus: "Who gave you a
decree to build this house and to finish this structure?" [4]They
also asked them this: "What are the names of the men who are
building this building?" [5]But the eye of their God was on the
elders of the Jews, and they did not stop them until the report
should reach Darius and then an answer be returned by letter
concerning it.

[6]This is a copy of the letter that Tattenai the governor of
the province Beyond the River and Shethar-bozenai and his
associates, the governors who were in the province Beyond
the River, sent to Darius the king. [7]They sent him a report, in
which was written as follows: "To Darius the king, all peace.
[8]Be it known to the king that we went to the province of

Judah, to the house of the great God. It is being built with
huge stones, and timber is laid in the walls. This work goes on
diligently and prospers in their hands. 9 Then we asked those
elders and spoke to them thus: 'Who gave you a decree to
build this house and to finish this structure?' 10 We also asked
them their names, for your information, that we might write
down the names of their leaders. 11 And this was their reply to
us: 'We are the servants of the God of heaven and earth, and we
are rebuilding the house that was built many years ago, which
a great king of Israel built and finished. 12 But because our
fathers had angered the God of heaven, he gave them into the
hand of Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon, the Chaldean, who
destroyed this house and carried away the people to Babylonia.
13 However, in the first year of Cyrus king of Babylon, Cyrus
the king made a decree that this house of God should be
rebuilt. 14 And the gold and silver vessels of the house of God,
which Nebuchadnezzar had taken out of the temple that was
in Jerusalem and brought into the temple of Babylon, these
Cyrus the king took out of the temple of Babylon, and they
were delivered to one whose name was Sheshbazzar, whom he
had made governor; 15 and he said to him, "Take these vessels,
go and put them in the temple that is in Jerusalem, and let the
house of God be rebuilt on its site." 16 Then this Sheshbazzar
came and laid the foundations of the house of God that is in
Jerusalem, and from that time until now it has been in build-
ing, and it is not yet finished.' 17 Therefore, if it seems good
to the king, let search be made in the royal archives there in
Babylon, to see whether a decree was issued by Cyrus the king

for the rebuilding of this house of God in Jerusalem. And let
the king send us his pleasure in this matter."

6 Then Darius the king made a decree, and search was made
in Babylonia, in the house of the archives where the docu-
ments were stored. 2 And in Ecbatana, the citadel that is in
the province of Media, a scroll was found on which this was
written: "A record. 3 In the first year of Cyrus the king, Cyrus
the king issued a decree: Concerning the house of God at
Jerusalem, let the house be rebuilt, the place where sacrifices
were offered, and let its foundations be retained. Its height
shall be sixty cubits and its breadth sixty cubits, 4 with three
layers of great stones and one layer of timber. Let the cost be
paid from the royal treasury. 5 And also let the gold and silver
vessels of the house of God, which Nebuchadnezzar took out
of the temple that is in Jerusalem and brought to Babylon, be
restored and brought back to the temple that is in Jerusalem,
each to its place. You shall put them in the house of God."

6 "Now therefore, Tattenai, governor of the province
Beyond the River, Shethar-bozenai, and your associates the
governors who are in the province Beyond the River, keep
away. 7 Let the work on this house of God alone. Let the gover-
nor of the Jews and the elders of the Jews rebuild this house of
God on its site. 8 Moreover, I make a decree regarding what you
shall do for these elders of the Jews for the rebuilding of this
house of God. The cost is to be paid to these men in full and
without delay from the royal revenue, the tribute of the prov-
ince from Beyond the River. 9 And whatever is needed — bulls,
rams, or sheep for burnt offerings to the God of heaven, wheat,

salt, wine, or oil, as the priests at Jerusalem require—let that
be given to them day by day without fail, [10] that they may offer
pleasing sacrifices to the God of heaven and pray for the life
of the king and his sons. [11] Also I make a decree that if anyone
alters this edict, a beam shall be pulled out of his house, and
he shall be impaled on it, and his house shall be made a dung-
hill. [12] May the God who has caused his name to dwell there
overthrow any king or people who shall put out a hand to
alter this, or to destroy this house of God that is in Jerusalem.
I Darius make a decree; let it be done with all diligence."

[13] Then, according to the word sent by Darius the king,
Tattenai, the governor of the province Beyond the River,
Shethar-bozenai, and their associates did with all diligence
what Darius the king had ordered. [14] And the elders of the Jews
built and prospered through the prophesying of Haggai the
prophet and Zechariah the son of Iddo. They finished their
building by decree of the God of Israel and by decree of Cyrus
and Darius and Artaxerxes king of Persia; [15] and this house was
finished on the third day of the month of Adar, in the sixth
year of the reign of Darius the king.

[16] And the people of Israel, the priests and the Levites, and
the rest of the returned exiles, celebrated the dedication of
this house of God with joy. [17] They offered at the dedication of
this house of God 100 bulls, 200 rams, 400 lambs, and as a sin
offering for all Israel 12 male goats, according to the number
of the tribes of Israel. [18] And they set the priests in their divi-
sions and the Levites in their divisions, for the service of God
at Jerusalem, as it is written in the Book of Moses.

[19] On the fourteenth day of the first month, the returned
exiles kept the Passover. [20] For the priests and the Levites had
purified themselves together; all of them were clean. So they
slaughtered the Passover lamb for all the returned exiles, for
their fellow priests, and for themselves. [21] It was eaten by the
people of Israel who had returned from exile, and also by every
one who had joined them and separated himself from the
uncleanness of the peoples of the land to worship the LORD,
the God of Israel. [22] And they kept the Feast of Unleavened Bread
seven days with joy, for the LORD had made them joyful and
had turned the heart of the king of Assyria to them, so that he
aided them in the work of the house of God, the God of Israel.

EZRA'S REFORMS

7 Now after this, in the reign of Artaxerxes king of Persia,
Ezra the son of Seraiah, son of Azariah, son of Hilkiah,
[2] son of Shallum, son of Zadok, son of Ahitub, [3] son of
Amariah, son of Azariah, son of Meraioth, [4] son of Zerahiah,
son of Uzzi, son of Bukki, [5] son of Abishua, son of Phinehas,
son of Eleazar, son of Aaron the chief priest—[6] this Ezra
went up from Babylonia. He was a scribe skilled in the Law
of Moses that the LORD, the God of Israel, had given, and the
king granted him all that he asked, for the hand of the LORD
his God was on him.

[7] And there went up also to Jerusalem, in the seventh year
of Artaxerxes the king, some of the people of Israel, and some

of the priests and Levites, the singers and gatekeepers, and
the temple servants. [8]And Ezra came to Jerusalem in the fifth
month, which was in the seventh year of the king. [9]For on the
first day of the first month he began to go up from Babylonia,
and on the first day of the fifth month he came to Jerusalem,
for the good hand of his God was on him. [10]For Ezra had set
his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to
teach his statutes and rules in Israel.

[11]This is a copy of the letter that King Artaxerxes gave to Ezra
the priest, the scribe, a man learned in matters of the command-
ments of the LORD and his statutes for Israel: [12]"Artaxerxes, king
of kings, to Ezra the priest, the scribe of the Law of the God of
heaven. Peace. And now [13]I make a decree that anyone of the
people of Israel or their priests or Levites in my kingdom, who
freely offers to go to Jerusalem, may go with you. [14]For you are
sent by the king and his seven counselors to make inquiries
about Judah and Jerusalem according to the Law of your God,
which is in your hand, [15]and also to carry the silver and gold
that the king and his counselors have freely offered to the God
of Israel, whose dwelling is in Jerusalem, [16]with all the silver and
gold that you shall find in the whole province of Babylonia, and
with the freewill offerings of the people and the priests, vowed
willingly for the house of their God that is in Jerusalem. [17]With
this money, then, you shall with all diligence buy bulls, rams,
and lambs, with their grain offerings and their drink offerings,
and you shall offer them on the altar of the house of your God
that is in Jerusalem. [18]Whatever seems good to you and your
brothers to do with the rest of the silver and gold, you may

do, according to the will of your God. [19]The vessels that have
been given you for the service of the house of your God, you
shall deliver before the God of Jerusalem. [20]And whatever else
is required for the house of your God, which it falls to you to
provide, you may provide it out of the king's treasury.

[21]"And I, Artaxerxes the king, make a decree to all the trea-
surers in the province Beyond the River: Whatever Ezra the
priest, the scribe of the Law of the God of heaven, requires of
you, let it be done with all diligence, [22]up to 100 talents of sil-
ver, 100 cors of wheat, 100 baths of wine, 100 baths of oil, and
salt without prescribing how much. [23]Whatever is decreed by
the God of heaven, let it be done in full for the house of the
God of heaven, lest his wrath be against the realm of the king
and his sons. [24]We also notify you that it shall not be lawful to
impose tribute, custom, or toll on anyone of the priests, the
Levites, the singers, the doorkeepers, the temple servants, or
other servants of this house of God.

[25]"And you, Ezra, according to the wisdom of your God
that is in your hand, appoint magistrates and judges who may
judge all the people in the province Beyond the River, all such
as know the laws of your God. And those who do not know
them, you shall teach. [26]Whoever will not obey the law of your
God and the law of the king, let judgment be strictly executed
on him, whether for death or for banishment or for confisca-
tion of his goods or for imprisonment."

[27]Blessed be the LORD, the God of our fathers, who put
such a thing as this into the heart of the king, to beautify the
house of the LORD that is in Jerusalem, [28]and who extended to

me his steadfast love before the king and his counselors, and
before all the king's mighty officers. I took courage, for the
hand of the LORD my God was on me, and I gathered leading
men from Israel to go up with me.

8 These are the heads of their fathers' houses, and this is the
genealogy of those who went up with me from Babylonia,
in the reign of Artaxerxes the king: [2]Of the sons of Phinehas,
Gershom. Of the sons of Ithamar, Daniel. Of the sons of David,
Hattush. [3]Of the sons of Shecaniah, who was of the sons of
Parosh, Zechariah, with whom were registered 150 men. [4]Of
the sons of Pahath-moab, Eliehoenai the son of Zerahiah,
and with him 200 men. [5]Of the sons of Zattu, Shecaniah the
son of Jahaziel, and with him 300 men. [6]Of the sons of Adin,
Ebed the son of Jonathan, and with him 50 men. [7]Of the sons
of Elam, Jeshaiah the son of Athaliah, and with him 70 men.
[8]Of the sons of Shephatiah, Zebadiah the son of Michael, and
with him 80 men. [9]Of the sons of Joab, Obadiah the son of
Jehiel, and with him 218 men. [10]Of the sons of Bani, Shelomith
the son of Josiphiah, and with him 160 men. [11]Of the sons of
Bebai, Zechariah, the son of Bebai, and with him 28 men. [12]Of
the sons of Azgad, Johanan the son of Hakkatan, and with
him 110 men. [13]Of the sons of Adonikam, those who came
later, their names being Eliphelet, Jeuel, and Shemaiah, and
with them 60 men. [14]Of the sons of Bigvai, Uthai and Zaccur,
and with them 70 men.

[15]I gathered them to the river that runs to Ahava, and
there we camped three days. As I reviewed the people and the
priests, I found there none of the sons of Levi. [16]Then I sent for

Eliezer, Ariel, Shemaiah, Elnathan, Jarib, Elnathan, Nathan,
Zechariah, and Meshullam, leading men, and for Joiarib and
Elnathan, who were men of insight, [17]and sent them to Iddo,
the leading man at the place Casiphia, telling them what to
say to Iddo and his brothers and the temple servants at the
place Casiphia, namely, to send us ministers for the house
of our God. [18]And by the good hand of our God on us, they
brought us a man of discretion, of the sons of Mahli the son
of Levi, son of Israel, namely Sherebiah with his sons and kins-
men, 18; [19]also Hashabiah, and with him Jeshaiah of the sons
of Merari, with his kinsmen and their sons, 20; [20]besides 220
of the temple servants, whom David and his officials had set
apart to attend the Levites. These were all mentioned by name.

[21]Then I proclaimed a fast there, at the river Ahava, that
we might humble ourselves before our God, to seek from him
a safe journey for ourselves, our children, and all our goods.
[22]For I was ashamed to ask the king for a band of soldiers and
horsemen to protect us against the enemy on our way, since
we had told the king, "The hand of our God is for good on all
who seek him, and the power of his wrath is against all who
forsake him." [23]So we fasted and implored our God for this,
and he listened to our entreaty.

[24]Then I set apart twelve of the leading priests: Sherebiah,
Hashabiah, and ten of their kinsmen with them. [25]And
I weighed out to them the silver and the gold and the ves-
sels, the offering for the house of our God that the king and
his counselors and his lords and all Israel there present had
offered. [26]I weighed out into their hand 650 talents of silver,

and silver vessels worth 200 talents, and 100 talents of gold,
[27] 20 bowls of gold worth 1,000 darics, and two vessels of fine
bright bronze as precious as gold. [28] And I said to them, "You
are holy to the LORD, and the vessels are holy, and the silver
and the gold are a freewill offering to the LORD, the God of
your fathers. [29] Guard them and keep them until you weigh
them before the chief priests and the Levites and the heads of
fathers' houses in Israel at Jerusalem, within the chambers of
the house of the LORD." [30] So the priests and the Levites took
over the weight of the silver and the gold and the vessels, to
bring them to Jerusalem, to the house of our God.

[31] Then we departed from the river Ahava on the twelfth day
of the first month, to go to Jerusalem. The hand of our God
was on us, and he delivered us from the hand of the enemy
and from ambushes by the way. [32] We came to Jerusalem, and
there we remained three days. [33] On the fourth day, within the
house of our God, the silver and the gold and the vessels were
weighed into the hands of Meremoth the priest, son of Uriah,
and with him was Eleazar the son of Phinehas, and with them
were the Levites, Jozabad the son of Jeshua and Noadiah the
son of Binnui. [34] The whole was counted and weighed, and the
weight of everything was recorded.

[35] At that time those who had come from captivity, the
returned exiles, offered burnt offerings to the God of Israel,
twelve bulls for all Israel, ninety-six rams, seventy-seven
lambs, and as a sin offering twelve male goats. All this was a
burnt offering to the LORD. [36] They also delivered the king's
commissions to the king's satraps and to the governors of the

province Beyond the River, and they aided the people and the
house of God.

9 After these things had been done, the officials approached
me and said, "The people of Israel and the priests and the
Levites have not separated themselves from the peoples of
the lands with their abominations, from the Canaanites, the
Hittites, the Perizzites, the Jebusites, the Ammonites, the
Moabites, the Egyptians, and the Amorites. [2] For they have
taken some of their daughters to be wives for themselves and
for their sons, so that the holy race has mixed itself with the
peoples of the lands. And in this faithlessness the hand of the
officials and chief men has been foremost." [3] As soon as I heard
this, I tore my garment and my cloak and pulled hair from my
head and beard and sat appalled. [4] Then all who trembled at
the words of the God of Israel, because of the faithlessness of
the returned exiles, gathered around me while I sat appalled
until the evening sacrifice. [5] And at the evening sacrifice I rose
from my fasting, with my garment and my cloak torn, and
fell upon my knees and spread out my hands to the LORD my
God, [6] saying:

"O my God, I am ashamed and blush to lift my face to you,
my God, for our iniquities have risen higher than our heads,
and our guilt has mounted up to the heavens. [7] From the days
of our fathers to this day we have been in great guilt. And for
our iniquities we, our kings, and our priests have been given
into the hand of the kings of the lands, to the sword, to cap-
tivity, to plundering, and to utter shame, as it is today. [8] But
now for a brief moment favor has been shown by the LORD

our God, to leave us a remnant and to give us a secure hold
within his holy place, that our God may brighten our eyes and
grant us a little reviving in our slavery. 9 For we are slaves. Yet
our God has not forsaken us in our slavery, but has extended
to us his steadfast love before the kings of Persia, to grant us
some reviving to set up the house of our God, to repair its
ruins, and to give us protection in Judea and Jerusalem.

10 "And now, O our God, what shall we say after this? For
we have forsaken your commandments, 11 which you com-
manded by your servants the prophets, saying, 'The land that
you are entering, to take possession of it, is a land impure
with the impurity of the peoples of the lands, with their
abominations that have filled it from end to end with their
uncleanness. 12 Therefore do not give your daughters to
their sons, neither take their daughters for your sons, and
never seek their peace or prosperity, that you may be strong
and eat the good of the land and leave it for an inheritance to
your children forever.' 13 And after all that has come upon us
for our evil deeds and for our great guilt, seeing that you, our
God, have punished us less than our iniquities deserved and
have given us such a remnant as this, 14 shall we break your
commandments again and intermarry with the peoples who
practice these abominations? Would you not be angry with
us until you consumed us, so that there should be no rem-
nant, nor any to escape? 15 O LORD, the God of Israel, you are
just, for we are left a remnant that has escaped, as it is today.
Behold, we are before you in our guilt, for none can stand
before you because of this."

10 While Ezra prayed and made confession, weeping and
casting himself down before the house of God, a very great
assembly of men, women, and children, gathered to him out
of Israel, for the people wept bitterly. 2 And Shecaniah the son
of Jehiel, of the sons of Elam, addressed Ezra: "We have broken
faith with our God and have married foreign women from the
peoples of the land, but even now there is hope for Israel in
spite of this. 3 Therefore let us make a covenant with our God
to put away all these wives and their children, according to
the counsel of my lord and of those who tremble at the com-
mandment of our God, and let it be done according to the
Law. 4 Arise, for it is your task, and we are with you; be strong
and do it." 5 Then Ezra arose and made the leading priests and
Levites and all Israel take an oath that they would do as had
been said. So they took the oath.

6 Then Ezra withdrew from before the house of God and
went to the chamber of Jehohanan the son of Eliashib, where
he spent the night, neither eating bread nor drinking water,
for he was mourning over the faithlessness of the exiles. 7 And
a proclamation was made throughout Judah and Jerusalem to
all the returned exiles that they should assemble at Jerusalem,
8 and that if anyone did not come within three days, by order of
the officials and the elders all his property should be forfeited,
and he himself banned from the congregation of the exiles.

9 Then all the men of Judah and Benjamin assembled at
Jerusalem within the three days. It was the ninth month, on
the twentieth day of the month. And all the people sat in the
open square before the house of God, trembling because of

this matter and because of the heavy rain. [10]And Ezra the priest
stood up and said to them, "You have broken faith and mar-
ried foreign women, and so increased the guilt of Israel. [11]Now
then make confession to the LORD, the God of your fathers and
do his will. Separate yourselves from the peoples of the land
and from the foreign wives." [12]Then all the assembly answered
with a loud voice, "It is so; we must do as you have said. [13]But
the people are many, and it is a time of heavy rain; we cannot
stand in the open. Nor is this a task for one day or for two, for
we have greatly transgressed in this matter. [14]Let our officials
stand for the whole assembly. Let all in our cities who have
taken foreign wives come at appointed times, and with them
the elders and judges of every city, until the fierce wrath of our
God over this matter is turned away from us." [15]Only Jonathan
the son of Asahel and Jahzeiah the son of Tikvah opposed this,
and Meshullam and Shabbethai the Levite supported them.

[16]Then the returned exiles did so. Ezra the priest selected
men, heads of fathers' houses, according to their fathers'
houses, each of them designated by name. On the first day of
the tenth month they sat down to examine the matter; [17]and
by the first day of the first month they had come to the end of
all the men who had married foreign women.

[18]Now there were found some of the sons of the priests
who had married foreign women: Maaseiah, Eliezer, Jarib,
and Gedaliah, some of the sons of Jeshua the son of Jozadak
and his brothers. [19]They pledged themselves to put away their
wives, and their guilt offering was a ram of the flock for their
guilt. [20]Of the sons of Immer: Hanani and Zebadiah. [21]Of

the sons of Harim: Maaseiah, Elijah, Shemaiah, Jehiel, and
Uzziah. [22]Of the sons of Pashhur: Elioenai, Maaseiah, Ishmael,
Nethanel, Jozabad, and Elasah.

[23]Of the Levites: Jozabad, Shimei, Kelaiah (that is, Kelita),
Pethahiah, Judah, and Eliezer. [24]Of the singers: Eliashib. Of
the gatekeepers: Shallum, Telem, and Uri.

[25]And of Israel: of the sons of Parosh: Ramiah, Izziah,
Malchijah, Mijamin, Eleazar, Hashabiah, and Benaiah.
[26]Of the sons of Elam: Mattaniah, Zechariah, Jehiel, Abdi,
Jeremoth, and Elijah. [27]Of the sons of Zattu: Elioenai, Eliashib,
Mattaniah, Jeremoth, Zabad, and Aziza. [28]Of the sons of Bebai
were Jehohanan, Hananiah, Zabbai, and Athlai. [29]Of the sons
of Bani were Meshullam, Malluch, Adaiah, Jashub, Sheal,
and Jeremoth. [30]Of the sons of Pahath-moab: Adna, Chelal,
Benaiah, Maaseiah, Mattaniah, Bezalel, Binnui, and Manasseh.
[31]Of the sons of Harim: Eliezer, Isshijah, Malchijah, Shemaiah,
Shimeon, [32]Benjamin, Malluch, and Shemariah. [33]Of the sons
of Hashum: Mattenai, Mattattah, Zabad, Eliphelet, Jeremai,
Manasseh, and Shimei. [34]Of the sons of Bani: Maadai, Amram,
Uel, [35]Benaiah, Bedeiah, Cheluhi, [36]Vaniah, Meremoth,
Eliashib, [37]Mattaniah, Mattenai, Jaasu. [38]Of the sons of Binnui:
Shimei, [39]Shelemiah, Nathan, Adaiah, [40]Machnadebai, Shashai,
Sharai, [41]Azarel, Shelemiah, Shemariah, [42]Shallum, Amariah,
and Joseph. [43]Of the sons of Nebo: Jeiel, Mattithiah, Zabad,
Zebina, Jaddai, Joel, and Benaiah. [44]All these had married for-
eign women, and some of the women had even borne children.